

RALLY!

The volleyball duel card game — Rulebook

2 PLAYERS • AGES 10+ • ~15 MINUTES • 31 CARDS • v0.3

OVERVIEW

In **Rally!**, two players face off in a volleyball match played entirely with cards. Every card is a real volleyball touch — **Bump**, **Set** and **Spike** — and, just like on the court, the order of touches matters: you dig the ball up, set the play, and attack. The ball crosses the net with every play, and the rally only ends when someone can't defend.

Goal: be the first player to score **3 points**. You score a point whenever your opponent cannot defend your attack.

COMPONENTS

- **30 play cards** (12 Bumps, 9 Sets, 9 Spikes)
- **1 Serve card**

BUMP ×12

DEFENSE 5–10 /
ATTACK 1–3
Your team's wall. **Defends against any play**, including Spikes. It opens the attack sequence, but its Attack value **only counts when paired with the Serve**.

SET ×9

DEFENSE 2–4 / ATTACK 2–4
The bridge between defense and attack. Defends against anything **except Spikes**. It can only set up a Spike if it comes **after a Bump** in the same play.

SPIKE ×9

ATTACK 3–6
The finishing blow. Can only be played **after a Set** (which followed a Bump). It **cannot defend anything** and can only be defended by a Bump.

SERVE ×1

SPECIAL CARD
Starts every rally. It is played together with **1 card from your hand**: that card's Attack value sets the power of the serve.

SETUP

1. Shuffle the 30 play cards to form the **draw deck** (face down).
2. Reveal 3 cards next to the deck: this is the **market** (face-up cards).
3. Each player draws **3 cards** from the deck to form their hand.
4. Decide who goes first (any method works). That player takes the **Serve** card.

HOW TO PLAY

A match is a sequence of **rallies**. Each rally starts with a serve, and the ball goes back and forth until one player cannot defend — the other player then scores 1 point.



1. The serve

- The server plays the **Serve** card together with **any 1 card from their hand**. That card's **Attack** value is the power of the serve. (This is the only moment when a Bump's Attack value counts!)
- If the serve's power is **4 or higher**, it is a **spike serve**: it can only be defended by a Bump.
- After serving, the server refills their hand to 3 (see *Refill*).
- The receiving player draws **1 extra card** — their hand goes up to 4 cards before defending. That's the receiver's edge for organizing the first counter-attack, just like in real volleyball.

2. The defense

When the ball reaches your side with attack power X, you must play **1 defense card** with a **Defense value ≥ X**, respecting the card types:

THE INCOMING BALL IS A...	CAN BE DEFENDED BY
Spike (or spike serve, power ≥ 4)	Only a Bump
Pass (a Set, or a serve with power 1–3)	Bump or Set
Free ball (power 0)	Any card — even a Spike*

*Receiving a free ball with a Spike is a desperation dig: you survive, but that play can only return another free ball (power 0) — you can't build anything from it.

Can't defend? If no card in your hand can defend the incoming ball (not enough Defense, or the wrong type), your opponent scores **1 point**.

3. Building and returning

The card you defended with **starts your play**. From there, you may chain cards in true volleyball order — or stop at any moment and return the ball:

- **Defended with a Bump?** You may play a Set; after the Set, you may play a Spike. Or return the ball at any point.
- **Defended with a Set?** You can only return the ball directly — with no Bump before it, there's no way to set up a Spike.
- **Your attack power** is the sum of the Attack values of the cards in your play. **Exception:** the Bump's Attack does not count (it only scores when paired with the Serve).
- Returning with just the Bump = a **free ball** (power 0).
- If the last card of your play was a **Spike**, the ball crosses the net as a Spike (only a Bump defends it).

4. Refill — drawing back up

- At the end of your play (after returning the ball), **refill your hand to 3 cards**.
- For each card, choose: take a **face-up card from the market** or draw **face down from the deck**.
- Whenever a card leaves the market, immediately replace it with the top card of the deck.

- If the deck runs out, shuffle the discard pile to form a new deck.

5. Point scored? New rally

- The player who scored the point **serves the next rally**.
- **The player who conceded the point discards their entire hand and draws 3 fresh cards** — the team regroups. Nobody stays stuck with a hand that can't defend.
- All played cards go to the discard pile.

A FULL RALLY EXAMPLE

ANNA × BRUNO — ANNA SERVES

1. Anna plays the Serve together with a Spike (Atk 5) → a serve with power **5**. Since $5 \geq 4$, it's a **spike serve**: Bruno can only defend with a Bump. Anna refills her hand to 3.
2. Bruno receives the serve and draws 1 extra card (hand goes to 4). He defends with a **Bump Def 7** ($7 \geq 5$ ✓).
3. Bruno builds his play: he plays a **Set Atk 3** and finishes with a **Spike Atk 6**. Attack power: $3 + 6 = 9$ (the Bump doesn't count). The ball crosses the net as a Spike.
4. Bruno refills his hand to 3, taking one card from the market and one from the deck.
5. Anna needs a Bump with Defense ≥ 9 . Her best Bump has Def 8 — **no defense!** Bruno scores 1 point (0×1).
6. Anna discards her hand and draws 3 fresh cards. Bruno serves the next rally.

Strategy tip: spending your best Spike on the serve creates a devastating spike serve — but you won't have it for the Bump → Set → Spike combo. Save it or risk it? That's the central decision of the game.

Defense tip: high-Defense Bumps (9–10) are the only cards that can stop the strongest combos (power 8–10). Keep an eye on the market whenever one shows up.

GAME END

The first player to score **3 points** wins the match. For a longer session, play a best-of-three or raise the target to 5 points.

QUICK REFERENCE

- **Win:** 3 points. Point = opponent failed to defend your attack.
- **Serve:** Serve + 1 card (its Attack is the power). Power ≥ 4 = spike serve. Receiver draws +1 card (hand of 4).
- **Defense:** card's Defense $\geq$ incoming power. Spikes only fall to Bumps. Free balls (0) can be received by any card.
- **Attack:** Bump → Set → Spike (you may stop early). Power = sum of Attack values (Bump doesn't count, except on the Serve).
- **Refill:** at the end of your play, hand goes back to 3 (market or deck).
- **After a point:** winner serves; loser swaps their entire hand for 3 fresh cards.